

10 May 2022

Tech500 Bootcamp Group Project Brief 2022

Overview

Your team has received an opportunity to pitch a technical solution for education. Your remit is broad; you can focus on improving formal educational systems, or teaching people about a niche topic. Your goal is to improve users' understanding of a topic and/or their experience in the process of learning. If you took part in last years' Bootcamp or the Tech500 Hackathon, you cannot repeat material for this project.

Brief

Your team needs to design an **innovative tech solution** to improve education. Your proposals must be evidence-based, demonstrate a clear business plan, and include either a platform demonstration, mockup, or prototype.

You should consider:

- What problem your tech solution aims to solve
- Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) considerations of your product
- Existing products/companies/competitors
- Your expected user-base and target market
- Which technology is best placed to solve the problem that you have identified, and suits your teams' skill set
- UX/UI
- How you plan to market the product
- How you plan to scale your product over time
- What potential challenges you might face

Components to include:

As well as demonstrating a clear consideration of the above, you should include a demonstration, mockup, or prototype of your tech solution. You should also justify any coding/technical decisions to demonstrate your understanding of technical resources and processes.

At the end of the Bootcamp, you will be pitching your product to a panel of three judges. Your presentation should be no longer than 8 minutes in length, and you should prepare for 1-2 questions from the judges. You may also include a handout (1 side of A4) to be handed to the judges. Any slides/handouts should be downloaded as a pdf, and sent to mabel.canham@upreach.org.uk at/before 12pm on the 30th June.

Turn to page 4 for the full marking criteria.

Team Roles and expectations

Your team will consist of members across all three streams: Tech, Business, and Product. It is expected that you take each person's expertise, interests, and capacity into account to divide responsibilities. However, all members of the team should be able to speak about other areas of the project, and decisions should be made as a team. Below are a few suggestions of roles that you/your team members may take. You can create a new/hybrid role if you feel this is necessary for your team, or assign multiple people to the same role.

1. Technology Officer(s)

Responsible for coding/ developing the product/product infrastructure, as well as developing the technical strategy. This role also involves ensuring that the tech team is meeting deadlines, and using their time productively/efficiently.

Task Focus: Oversee the overall development of the product, ensuring the tech team is working efficiently.

How do I go about this task? Collaborate with Tech team to decide on priorities, set internal deadlines for the Tech team, ensure team is working to schedule, coding/developing product, considering which technology to use.

2. Product Manager(s)

Responsible for positioning the product to convey the value it offers and the problem it aims to solve. They will need to help the team with strategy, understand what the strategic goals of the product are, and ensure the product aligns with these goals. They will also need to support the creation of product features, set the strategic requirements for features and understand how they will benefit the users' experience

Task Focus: Understand strategic aims of features/the product, ensuring both are in line with overall goals, and communicate the value of the product internally and externally.

How do I go about this task? Research the solution area to understand the problem this product aims to solve, and why this product will be a valuable solution, collaborate with the Tech team on product features, conduct research of users, collaborate with marketing/business team to develop marketing/business strategy.

3. Project Manager

They will be responsible for overseeing the overall organisation and completion of the project. This includes understanding the brief, organising meetings, reviewing progress, setting priorities/deadlines, and setting strategic goals with the support of the rest of the team.

Task focus: Ensure that the project is completed on time, and to a high standard, by keeping the team on-track, identifying risks, and ensuring quality control.

How do I go about this task? Clarify objectives and define the scope of the project, set milestones and priorities, organise the team, identify potential problems and consider solutions.

4. Business Strategist(s)

Responsible for researching the market for the product, identifying competitors, and developing an overall business strategy to build/develop the product. This role will include working on pitching the product to potential investors, and liaising closely with the product manager, project manager, and marketing officer to understand user-base and product strategy as well as product messaging.

Task focus: Develop a pitch for the product by understanding existing markets, evaluating competitors, and considering how to build and scale the product.

How do I go about this task? Research competitors/existing products, collaborate with the product/project managers to understand the problem/solution area, develop commercial/sector awareness that may affect the team/product.

5. Marketing Officer (s)

Responsible for developing a marketing plan to attract users to the product. Work with the Business Strategist, Product Manager and Project Manager to decide on key selling points, markets, and opportunities. Work with the Tech team to ensure user engagement and retention with the product.

Task focus: Develop marketing strategy to ensure high user retention, engagement, and product growth.

How do I go about this task? Develop a central 'message' to communicate the value of your product externally, develop brand identity for the product, highlight key messages/opportunities for marketing, identify gaps in market/current trends to launch product, develop pitch/presentation for judges.

6. UX Designer(s) / Visual Designer

Responsible for ensuring the practical execution of the design and how it is perceived by the users. They keep the entire concept coherent and ensure that there is no obstacle in the user's whole journey through the product to ensure a smooth user experience. Based on research, they ensure that the visual components are user-friendly, engaging, and provide a rich user experience. They will also outline all expected interactions within the product and develop user-journeys.

Task Focus: Your role as a UX Designer ensures that users have the perfect functionality, that meets their expectations, and make the overall experience error-free, with a firm understanding of how users navigate through the product/ application.

How do I go about this task? User research, user journey mapping, user personas, design thinking brainstorming sessions, develop Workflow, wire-frames, whiteboard sessions, task flow diagrams, overall layout, typography, patterns, iconography, micro-interactions, colour palettes, design systems, etc.

Marking Criteria:

Skill	Criteria
Project Management:	Collaboration between team members
	Time management/organisation
	Clear consideration of scope
Communication/Presentation:	Speaking clearly and persuasively
	Active listening skills (including with other groups)
	Carefully considers feedback/criticism
	Positive/Enthusiastic
Problem-solving:	Innovative ideas
	Use of logic, research, and evidence to recommend solutions
	Strong analysis skills & attention to detail
	Consideration of impact/resources of suggestions
	Consideration of ESG/Ethical implications
Business Acumen	Confident delivery of pitch
	Understanding of product within market area/competitors
	Ability to field probing questions

Use of technology	Accessibility of product
	Product design meets strategic goals
	Product tailored to specific user-base
	Consideration of visual elements (colours, shapes, font etc)
	Sophistication of technical elements
	Intuitiveness of product/solution
	Interaction design
	Clear justification for technical elements and decisions

Additional Marking Information:

- Your presentation should be no longer than 8 minutes in length, and you should prepare for 1-2 questions from the judges/audience.
- Your proposals must be evidence-based, demonstrate a clear business plan, and include either a platform demonstration, mockup, or prototype. Please see page 1 of this document for the full brief.
- Judges will only be able to award marks based on presentations - for earlier processes (e.g., background research, project management etc), you will need to speak about these during the presentation, or include them in your handout.
- You will lose marks for going significantly over the time allowance (3+ minutes)
- You will not be penalised for taking less than the full 8 minutes to present, though if significantly under time, your presentation may be unlikely to achieve the appropriate level of detail or breadth to score highly.
- You will not be penalised if all members of the team do not speak during the presentation, but contributions to the project should be made clear through the presentation.
- You will receive extra marks for asking insightful questions to other groups (please be respectful, you will not get extra marks for picking holes in each others' products)